PORTLAND
Public Schools

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To: Portland Public Schools Board of Education

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Subject: PPS 2026 State of the Arts Report

Background

Thirteen years into the City of Portland's Arts Access Fund (Arts Tax) commitment, the students in Portland Public Schools' current graduating class were kindergarteners when arts education was first restored to their schools. Since that time, PPS has worked not only to preserve access to arts education across the district but also to build a more coherent and student-centered arts education system over time.

The development and implementation of the PPS Master Arts Education Plan (MAEP) established a districtwide strategic framework intended to guide this work. Through the MAEP, PPS defined key conditions necessary for equitable, comprehensive, high-quality arts education, including access and time, meaningful learning experiences, student performance and voice, authentic learning spaces, and instructional materials and resources.

At the same time, the City of Portland has continued developing the Portland Arts Education Framework in collaboration with the six Arts Access Fund school districts and researchers from Portland State University. The framework represents an increasing emphasis on consistency, visibility, and accountability around arts education conditions across schools and districts. The current year represents a pilot year for portions of this work and includes annual school-level data collection processes aligned to the City's framework, alongside development of a future public-facing dashboard intended to provide greater visibility into arts education conditions over time.

Strategic Alignment & Implementation

PPS is well-positioned for this work because many of the conditions now being measured through the City's evolving framework are already reflected within the district's existing strategic planning and implementation efforts. Since the launch of the MAEP, PPS has continued expanding and refining arts education systems across multiple areas, including K–12 pathway development, curriculum alignment, district-wide and site-based capstone performance and

exhibition, stakeholder engagement structures, and systems for monitoring implementation over time.

One example highlighted in the accompanying presentation is the Roosevelt cluster, where targeted pathway investments beginning in 2016 expanded music programming from two schools to all schools across the cluster. This cluster-based implementation approach later informed broader district efforts to strengthen pathway continuity and reduce inequities in arts access across PPS school communities. Today, all clusters in PPS offer K-12 pathways of study in both visual and performing arts.

As annual reporting structures and public-facing data systems continue to evolve, PPS will have increasing opportunities to understand better how students experience arts education across schools and over time. The current pilot year provides the district an opportunity to internally review emerging data, identify areas requiring further alignment and support, and continue refining systems prior to broader public-facing implementation.

PPS has also continued investing in structures intended to support stakeholder engagement and continuous improvement, including ongoing collaboration with the PPS Arts Education Advisory Council and the launch of the Student Voice Committee as part of MAEP implementation efforts.

Connection to Board Goals

This work aligns directly with PPS Board goals related to student engagement, belonging, well-rounded educational experiences, robust secondary pathways, and college and career readiness. Recent internal analysis conducted by PPS's Research, Assessment, and Accountability department found that students enrolled in visual and performing arts courses outpaced district averages in both attendance and chronic absenteeism measures between 2023 and 2025, suggesting that sustained participation in arts learning may play an important role in student connection and engagement with school communities.

Ultimately, this work is about more than access alone. It is about ensuring that students across every school community experience arts learning environments that support creativity, critical thinking, cultural literacy, personal voice, belonging, and meaningful participation in school life. As PPS continues implementing the MAEP alongside the evolving City framework, the district remains committed to strengthening the conditions that enable all students to engage in high-quality arts learning experiences over time.